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Culture (OWC): [Bagisu \(FK13\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: August 1965-June 1969

Coverage Date: 1960s

Place Coverage

Bugisu District, Mount Elgon region, Uganda

Section Title(S): THE PLAN OF THE BOOK

Chapter 8 turns to the management of hostilities in the neighbourhood at the present day. On the one hand, these may be characterised as strategies of impotence; lacking the ability to act concertedly against outsiders, Gisu kin groups can offer no protection to their members. On the other, individual autonomy is seen as basic, carrying with it the right to act in one's own interest and one's own defence. The point of intersection between individual right and community right is thus the cutting edge of the system. On the one hand, it breeds self-help; on the other, it breeds intolerance for those who are deemed to have gone beyond the pale, who are seen as having forfeited all rights. The 'troublemaker', whether an adulterer, thief, witch or slanderer, is one who in pursuing his own self-interest violates the interest of others. The main part of this chapter is taken up with an extended case study which details the reaction of people in a neighbourhood following a murder. The strategies which people use for limiting the repercussions of such events within the community are detailed in order to bring out the extreme importance of character assessment and the nature of Gisu morality.

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The question of morality is taken further in the following chapter (9) when the discussion of kinship expands to include a cosmological dimension. In looking at beliefs about ancestors, a particular focus is on the nature of Gisu ancestor beliefs in a system which recognises neither segmentary loyalty nor the authority of elders. Some of this takes the form of a dialogue with Fortes (especially, 1959, 1969), against whom I argue that what is basic to Gisu kinship is not amity but rather a continuity which is ensured through ancestral transmission of a person's body, spirit and powers. More fundamentally, it is argued that kinship encodes an implicit philosophy of being and the final section of the chapter turns back to an unique form of peacemaking which was found in Bugisu. Here feuds were settled by contracting a joking relationship which combined the patterning of peace and hostility in a single relationship and in such a way as to demand an exploratory interpretation of its significance for the Gisu understanding of social relationships. Taken in conjunction with the avoidance relationship of son-in-law with mother-in-law, I

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interpret both these relationships as encoding contrasting dramas of self-denial, of sex in the  9 one instance and violence in the other. Not simply about the regulation of behaviour, they may be taken also as parables, speaking to the kinds of restraint people must exercise over themselves in order to achieve lasting relationships in an egalitarian community.

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